ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Clubs, Leadership and Volunteering: Build Skills Without Losing Your Semester

Choose activities that develop you and still leave room for your degree

CAMPUS LIFE

Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Extracurricular activity can build real skills or quietly consume your study time. This pack helps you choose a small number of commitments deliberately, contribute well, and record what you learn in a way that later helps with internships and job applications.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Choose activities aligned with your goals and available time.
- Contribute effectively in a team and handle responsibility reliably.
- Balance leadership roles with academic workload.
- Record achievements and skills for future applications.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Choose deliberately

Depth in two activities beats shallow membership in eight.

- Decide what you want to develop: communication, organisation, technical skill or a network.
- Attend a meeting before committing to a role.
- Ask current members how much time the role actually takes.
- Check that meetings do not clash with core lectures or labs.
- Prefer organisations with clear structures and real projects.
- Leave gracefully if an activity is consuming your study time.

Work well in a team

Reliability is the most valued trait in student teams.

- Confirm what you own and when it is due.
- Communicate early when a deadline is at risk.
- Write brief minutes with decisions and owners.
- Do the unglamorous tasks sometimes; it builds trust.
- Give credit publicly and correct privately.
- Document events with photos and simple reports for continuity.

> **Leadership is not a title**
> A treasurer who keeps clean records and a volunteer who shows up consistently are doing more leadership than a titleholder who disappears.

Record what you learn

Experience that cannot be described is hard to use later.

- Keep a simple log: role, dates, tasks, results and skills used.
- Quantify where possible: number of participants, funds raised, sessions organised.
- Collect one or two references from supervisors.
- Save certificates and photographs in a folder.
- Reflect on one failure each semester and what you changed.
- Turn the log into CV bullet points while details are fresh.

Why joining one thing well beats five things badly

Student organisations are where leadership is actually practised: organising an event, managing a budget, resolving a disagreement, recruiting and replacing people. These are the experiences employers and postgraduate selectors ask about, and they are only credible when you can describe something you actually did.

Choose by interest and by the quality of the existing members. A well-run small society teaches more than a large disorganised one. Attend two meetings before committing, and ask what the group achieved last year - not what it plans to achieve.

Depth beats breadth. Two years in one organisation with a progression from member to coordinator to officer is a stronger story than one semester in six groups.

Running something: the basic mechanics

Every event has five elements: purpose, people, plan, money and follow-up. Purpose states what the event is for and how you will know it worked. People means named roles rather than a committee of everyone. Plan means a timeline working backwards from the date. Money means a budget with receipts. Follow-up means thanking people and recording what to repeat.

Leadership in a student group is mostly communication and reliability. Say what you will do and when, then do it. When you cannot, say so early. A leader who is predictable is trusted with more than one who is impressive but unreliable.

Delegation is not dumping. Give a task with a clear outcome, a deadline, the authority to act, and an agreement about when you will check in. Then do not hover.

> **Write the handover**
> Before you leave a role, write one page: what you did, where the files are, who the contacts are, what failed and why. That page is the most useful thing you will leave behind.

Volunteering and its limits

Volunteering builds skills and relationships, and it should be chosen as deliberately as paid work. Ask what you will be doing, who you will report to, how much time it requires, and whether you will receive any training or reference. Vagueness in those answers predicts a frustrating experience.

Protect your studies. A volunteer role that costs you a semester is not a good trade, and good organisations will say so. Learn to decline: "I can commit two hours on Saturdays until the end of term" is a complete and respectable answer.

Ethics matter in volunteering too: do not accept a role you are not competent for, do not take photographs of vulnerable people without consent, and do not use a volunteer position primarily to collect a certificate.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Planning a departmental event

Your society will host a career talk in three weeks.

1. State the purpose and the success measure, such as attendance and follow-up enquiries.
2. Assign named roles: programme, publicity, logistics, finance, documentation.
3. Work backwards from the date: invitations two weeks before, venue confirmed one week before, materials three days before.
4. Write the budget and get approval before spending.
5. Confirm the speaker in writing with time, venue and transport details.
6. After the event, send thanks, collect feedback and write a one-page report.

> **What to carry forward**
> Purpose, roles, timeline, budget, follow-up. Skip any one and the event fails in a predictable way.

2. Handling a non-performing team member

A committee member has missed three deadlines.

1. Ask privately whether something has happened - illness, workload, confusion about the task.
2. Restate the specific commitment and the consequence of missing it.
3. Offer one concrete support: a smaller task, a partner, or a revised deadline.
4. Agree what happens if the next deadline is missed.
5. Record the agreement briefly and follow up.
6. If it repeats, redistribute the work rather than complaining to others.

> **What to carry forward**
> Ask, restate, support, agree consequences. Complaining to the group solves nothing.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the components of an effective event plan.

15 marks

1. Purpose and success measure.
2. Named roles and responsibilities.
3. Timeline worked backwards from the date.
4. Budget with approval and receipts.
5. Follow-up, feedback and records.

Q2. What makes delegation effective?

10 marks

1. Clear outcome and deadline.
2. Authority to act.
3. Agreed check-in points.
4. Support without hovering.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Handover. A written record of a role passed to a successor.

Delegation. Assigning a task with outcome, deadline and authority.

Accountability. Being answerable for a defined responsibility.

Budget approval. Formal permission to spend before expenditure occurs.

Success measure. The evidence that an activity achieved its purpose.

Quorum. The minimum attendance required for a decision to be valid.

Terms of reference. The stated purpose and powers of a committee or role.

Stakeholder. Anyone affected by or interested in an activity.

Follow-up. Post-event thanks, feedback and documentation.

Reference. A statement about your performance from someone who supervised you.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Choose

Selection.

- Attend two society meetings.
- Ask what the group achieved last year.
- Commit to one organisation.

Week 2 - Contribute

Reliability.

- Take one small named task.
- Deliver it early.
- Write down what the role involves.

Week 3 - Lead

Organising.

- Plan one activity with five elements.
- Delegate two tasks properly.
- Track the budget.

Week 4 - Record

Evidence.

- Write a one-page report of the activity.
- Collect feedback.
- Draft a handover note.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your Students' Union constitution and society registration rules.
- A short guide to running student events and budgets.
- A volunteering guide on expectations and safeguarding.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. How many activities should a first-year student join?

Answer: A small number - often one or two meaningful commitments - so that participation is real and study time is protected.

2. Why write minutes with owners?

Answer: They turn discussion into accountable action and prevent tasks from being forgotten or duplicated.

3. What should a contribution log contain?

Answer: Role, dates, tasks, measurable results, skills used and contacts for references.

4. How do you leave a role responsibly?

Answer: Give notice, hand over documentation and contacts, and complete outstanding commitments.

5. Why quantify achievements?

Answer: Numbers make contributions concrete and credible in CVs and interviews.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write the three skills you most want to develop.
- [ ] Attend one meeting before joining.
- [ ] Choose no more than two commitments for the semester.
- [ ] Create a contribution log with dates and results.
- [ ] Take on one specific responsibility and deliver it.
- [ ] Collect contact details for a reference.
- [ ] Review your commitments at mid-semester and adjust.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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